FRIGID

GIAO CHI

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IT WAS A THIRTEEN YEAR WAIT.

The original version of *The Girl Who Kept Winter*, titled *Tuyet Den* in Vietnamese, was published in Vietnam in 2007. Its sequel *Frigid*, originally titled *Liet Than*, was not published until 2020. That makes it the only series in Vietnamese literature in which the timeline in real life is longer than that of the novel.

I could not be more appreciative that after thirteen long years, the love and support for the book is still going strong, and it has given me the motivation to continue writing.

I want to dedicate *Liet Than* to the first generation of *Tuyet Den* readers, who had to wait thirteen years for the sequel.

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I also want to thank the team below, who didn't make *The Girl Who Kept Winter* readers wait as long:

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CHAPTER 1

A Disastrous Beauty

The long-awaited wedding of the town magistrate's dear son had become a massacre.

The reception was going to be extravagant: the tables were laden with delicious-looking food, the mouthwatering aroma that filled the air was heavenly, and the wine was exquisite. The guests themselves made a colorful picture in their finery—though it seemed every one of them had come armed to the teeth.

By the time Dong Tu arrived, everyone was dead.

Bodies were piled haphazardly on top of each other. Some had been hacked to pieces. Blood and gore pooled on the floor, sprayed the walls, and spattered the dead's faces, even as it stained their clothing a deep, rusty red. Dong Tu was shocked into a horrified silence.

The situation had escalated.

Could she have caused this slaughter?

It all began ten days before, on a late winter afternoon. The people of Vinh Phuc, young and old, had flocked to the pub. A fire blazed in the hearth at the center of the room, where guests sat warming themselves with strong wine. As they sat talking, exchanging gossip and rumors and spreading

news, a stranger stepped through the door with a short burst of cold winter air. The stranger was tall and slim, and their shining black, hip-length hair flowed out from beneath a hat that had a veil that fell in front of their face. It was impossible to discern whether they were a man or a woman from the way they moved.

The stranger seemed to have brought the winter sky inside with them: their luxurious, high-collared robe was the same crisp, cool blue, and as they walked, the white clothes beneath the robe were reminiscent of shifting clouds.

“Could you tell me where I might find a security escort?” they asked.

Everyone in the pub answered at once, all of them directing the stranger to the Luu family’s dojo.

“You know, *that* dojo!” one of the townspeople added, and was immediately cowed into silence by the shushes and warning looks thrown their way.

“What dojo?” the stranger asked, peering around the room from beneath the veil. No local person would have asked that question.

In a low voice, one man explained, “The Luu dojo is the most prestigious martial arts school in the district. They teach students, and they offer their services as guards. Their people escort carriages and shipments. They have an honest work ethic and are brave, capable people. Their business has boomed over the last two years, and every shipment they escort arrives safely. Thieves don’t dare to come near their carriages, and they’ve become the largest escort service in the region.”

“And?” the stranger pressed, growing impatient.

The man beckoned them closer, then continued in a whisper.

“The eldest daughter of the Luu Family, Luu Dong Tu, is young and beautiful, both inside and out—and she is a very skilled martial artist. The Luu dojo got famous because she had a love affair with a high-ranking member of the Poison Legion, a man called Obsidian, one of the Kings of Poison. He’s a cruel man who never hesitates to kill, which is why no one dares to mess with the Luu family. Crossing him means death.”

“‘Love affair’ is an exaggeration,” another man argued. “It’s been more than two years since Dong Tu came back, and there’s still no sign of Obsidian.”

“I heard that because of Dong Tu, the King of Poison nearly lost his life many times. Why would he risk death if he hadn’t been in love with her?” a woman pointed out.

Another man asked, “If it was such a strong relationship, why did he leave her for two years?”

“What was the relationship between the King of Poison and Dong Tu, then? Is it still going on?” the stranger asked.

Luu Dong Tu was old enough to be married, but no matter how beautiful and talented she was, she was doomed to be single forever because of her association with the Poison Legion. No man would show the slightest interest in her unless he had a death wish. Who would dare to flirt with the lover of the infamous Obsidian?

Most of the people in the pub were already tipsy by the time the stranger pressed for more information, and had gradually moved away from discussing the haphazard story, instead contemplating the marriage possibilities of the local beauties amongst themselves: who was at the age for dating, who was interesting, if there was any chance with them or not.

It seemed their time was up.

The veiled stranger paid for their wine and left.

Night was falling as the stranger arrived at the Luu dojo, and there, in addition to the Luu family, they found a tall, handsome young man and seven young women, all of them dressed in spotlessly white clothes.

Mr. Luu introduced them.

“This is Bach Duong, son of the famous General Bach. Today is a blissful day,” he said. “So many people have come to visit!”

The stranger in the veiled hat bowed their head slightly in greeting as Bach Duong swept his beautiful eyes over them from head to toe. Dong Tu herself came and served tea, and the stranger took the opportunity to study her closely from behind the veil.

Were the people of Vinh Phuc out of their minds? Compared to the true beauties of the world, Dong Tu was merely mediocre. Sure, she had adorable chubby cheeks, bright eyes, and a pretty mouth, but she was a bit short. Was this small woman really a famous fighter? Was it true that the King of Poison had willingly risked his life for her? There was no way to tell which parts of the story were true and which were embellishments.

The stranger couldn’t help but wonder if the reputation of the Luu family’s security service had been as inflated as Dong Tu’s beauty.

Dong Tu felt the guest’s judgmental stare and looked away uncomfortably. But like everyone else, she still took her own measure of the stranger: they were the same height as Bach Duong—who was very tall for a man. Even when sitting, their slim, well-proportioned body seemed to

tower over her. Their height and physique seemed to belong to a young man, but the flower brooch, the veiled hat, and the polished fingernails were clearly feminine.

After accepting the tea, the stranger finally removed their hat and placed it on the table. A cold breeze gently lifted their hair as they (needlessly) smoothed it back down, and everyone in the room stopped and studied their face for the first time. The stranger was extremely beautiful, a striking and even blend of masculine and feminine: their phoenix eyes were long and clear, and their nose had an exceptionally high ridge; the dimple between their nose and lip was as clear as a drop of water, and their lips were pouty and visibly soft. Their face was perfectly proportioned and glowing with a touch of soft pink blush and red-stained lips.

Teardrop earrings framed their face, and the stranger looked like they'd been plucked from a dream, stunning in ways that drew the beholder in and left them hypnotized. Looking at them felt like floating on a boat in the middle of an autumn lake, so absorbed that time and place melted away. Anyone, regardless of romantic preferences, would have found an ideal in this androgynous beauty.

The Luu family gasped as the stranger's extraordinary face registered. Bach Duong tilted his head and ran his fingers over his chin, smiling softly with instant infatuation. Dong Tu surreptitiously clicked her tongue, wondering how to address the stranger.

"My name is Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu." The stranger introduced themselves in a warm, deep voice. The name was both evocative and beautiful: *snowflakes flying in the wind*. It suited them well.

“I heard your dojo provides the best protection in the region. Is it possible to safely escort me to my home, Snowflake Tower in Lac Do, within seven days?”

Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu told the gathered group that they had fled from their home to avoid an arranged marriage, only to discover that in doing so, they had put their entire family in danger. They had decided to return and accept the marriage, but the trip was long, and they were weak, with no martial arts training. They needed an escort to protect them from robbery and rape.

“What a terrible plight, beautiful! How can I help?” Bach Duong cried, and then he kissed her hand.

Dong Tu thought, *The stranger must be female! Bach Duong would never have kissed a man.*

The sudden kiss startled Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu. She pulled her hand back angrily, and as she stared at Bach Duong in offense, her eyes began to tear up.

Dong Tu grabbed Bach Duong’s collar and shoved him away, stomping on his feet and glaring at him until he retreated to another seat. Bach Duong had a bad habit of kissing women without their consent. He had been criticized for it many times, but still hadn’t learned his lesson.

Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu took a handkerchief with lace-embroidered flowers from her robe and carefully wiped at the spot where Bach Duong had kissed her, still visibly upset that he had dared to touch her. Her offense reminded Dong Tu of those highborn ladies whose virginities were so belligerently guarded, as if Bach Duong had stolen her innocence away with that single kiss.

“Don’t worry, Miss Tuyet Hoa,” Dong Tu consoled her. “We will escort you home. I will accompany you personally.”

Hearing that, Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu looked unpleasantly surprised.

“Miss Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu, please don’t worry. Our Dong Tu is truly a skilled fighter. If you feel uneasy, we can arrange two more lead escorts to accompany her,” Mr. Luu quickly added.

Mr. Luu saw Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu’s look of dissatisfaction and, guessing that it might be because of how little Dong Tu seemed compared to her, he reassured her that while Dong Tu was small, she was so talented no ordinary thugs could surpass her. The trip would not take them through dangerous areas, and Dong Tu would easily keep them safe.

“All right then,” Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu accepted with a nod. She was still a little skeptical, but having seen how Dong Tu handled Bach Duong’s impetuous kiss, she was more prepared to let their reassurances put her at ease.

Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu finished her tea, then slowly lowered the cup, pushed her silky hair back behind her like a dark stream, and placed two gold taels on the table. She stood up, her earrings swaying, glanced at Bach Duong—whose eyes followed her with amorous longing—and headed off.

Dong Tu and Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu departed the next day, accompanied by two lead guards and Dong Tu’s adopted brother, a young man named Bao Thuong. The route from Vinh Phuc to Lac Do passed through many small districts and villages, residential and commercial areas, with many things to

see. The only part of the route that would require caution was a forest known to be a haven for bandits.

The first day of the trip went by without incident.

The biggest danger was that Bao Thuong kept staring at Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu, and picked flowers for her along the way. Dong Tu had to remind him several times to mind his manners. Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu was a client, and if he treated her disrespectfully it could damage the Luus' reputation.

Bao Thuong usually kept his distance from the Luus' clients, but he had never seen such beauty before. Lady Tuyet Hoa stood almost a head taller than he did, but she was as beautiful as a painting, and he had hope. Fortunately she wasn't offended, and sometimes covered her mouth to giggle at his silly behavior.

Dong Tu had been sympathetic to Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu's situation from the moment they met: she too had been robbed of the freedom to choose the man who would share her life. Though she would surely live in wealth, her days would be bland, lifeless, and lonely. She already felt that Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu was a beautiful person with a pleasant personality who did not deserve her fate, and before long, they were as close as sisters.

On the second night, as the travelers were eating dinner, Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu asked her, "Do you have a lover yet?"

It had been a long time since anyone had asked Dong Tu that question. In recent years, her private life had been made so public, she felt everyone in the world knew more about it than she herself. According to the rumors, Dong Tu had a relationship with Obsidian of the Poison Legion, who possessed the fabled Storm Pearl—and his every move was newsworthy. Dong Tu had become famous because of him. She shook her head.

“I’ve heard the King of Poison has black snow falling all around him because of something called the Storm Pearl,” Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu prompted.

Dong Tu nodded, but the challenge for she and Obsidian was not only that black snow fell with his every footstep. There were many other obstacles between Dong Tu and Obsidian, not the least of which being if they ever met again, they wouldn’t even be able to touch one another.

“The whole of Obsidian’s body is extremely poisonous,” Dong Tu explained. “Anyone who touches him will die sooner or later.” No one knew if fate would favor them in this life. Dong Tu hoped to meet him again one day, but it had been more than two years since she’d had any news of him, and her hopes were fading.

“You must move on and find yourself a boyfriend,” Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu told her. After all, they hadn’t seen each other for more than two years, and they couldn’t touch each other even if they did meet.

A bright laugh interrupted them.

“How daring of you! Did you know what you just said could’ve gotten you killed?”

Dong Tu looked up to see the woman who had been sitting at the table by them for some time. The woman stuffed her mouth with food, chewed, and let her fingers trail over Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu’s cheek. Dong Tu didn’t recognize the woman’s face, but she immediately knew who it was from that movement alone.

It was Switch, the Skinwalker, one of the Monstrous Eighteen. She was known for her ability to steal others’ faces and wear them as her own—and she was a friend of Obsidian’s.

“You’re talking nonsense. If Obsidian had heard what you said, you’d have a hard time staying alive.” Switch winked, still stroking Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu’s cheek. “My, your face is so beautiful!”

It was often said that beauty is a burden that brings only bad luck, and it was especially true when the person who admired that beauty was none other than the Skinwalker herself. Switch had been born faceless, and had developed a covetous passion for stealing the faces of the most beautiful people she could find.

“What a waste of such a beautiful face. If she’s gonna be killed by Obsidian, why not let me have her face first!” Switch said. Suddenly she jumped up and squatted on the table before Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu, her hands clasping that beautiful face.

Bao Thuong and the two Luu guards pulled out their swords while Dong Tu pushed back her chair and stood up.

“Don’t move!” she ordered. The two guards and Bao Thuong were no match for Switch. “Switch, please don’t. Please.” Her voice trembled slightly: Dong Tu knew that she was no match for the mutant, either. She would have to rely on their friendship to make her listen.

“I like this face! What are *you* going to do?” Switch laughed. “Are you going to cry to your lover?”

It had been a long time since Dong Tu had seen her, but Switch hadn’t become any easier to deal with.

Bao Thuong and the two escorts prepared to defend Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu, but instead of helping them, Dong Tu pushed all three away with the palm of her hand. Switch was a creature of the Whispered World, and was an

exceptionally, inhumanly gifted martial artist. The more people attacked her, the more lives would be lost.

Switch stood, grabbed Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu's shoulders, shrugged, and with a swift wind-walk, the two of them disappeared—leaving only a bright, echoing voice behind.

"Let me try this new face on!"

Dong Tu passed a hand over her face. A client hadn't been kidnapped on her watch for a very long time. Even worse, the kidnapper was *Switch*.

Over the years, Dong Tu had come to understand Switch's habits. To swap faces, she needed a secluded place where she could gather her chi, her inner strength. And in addition to stealing faces, Switch liked stealing entire identities. She would want to have a drink and chat with Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu for a while before swapping their faces.

Dong Tu hurriedly called for the shopkeeper and asked if there were any deserted areas or abandoned houses nearby.

Switch had indeed brought Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu to an abandoned hut nearby. She pushed Tuyet Hoa to the floor and pulled two bottles of wine from within her shirt: she'd realized that Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu wasn't trained in any kind of fighting, so she wasn't in a rush. She wanted to find out who this beauty was, and get to know the identity she planned to steal.

Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu didn't appreciate being pushed down. She dusted off her blue robe and stood, then raised a hand to catch the bottle of wine Switch had tossed at her. Switch smiled with satisfaction.

“Such a brave girl! Ordinary people would have been crying, pleading for mercy!”

“I’m on my way home to marry some good-for-nothing. What do I have to fear? I would be just as glad to die here.” Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu tipped her head back and drank straight from the bottle.

Switch narrowed her eyes. The girl’s manner was very familiar, and her response was suspicious. Was this prey truly brave, or was she so frightened she’d become calm? Tuyet Hoa’s demeanor reminded Switch of Dong Tu: hadn’t the time she kidnapped Dong Tu been a similar situation? That day, Obsidian had walked in and messed up her process, making it impossible to steal Dong Tu’s face. She would not miss the opportunity this time. Switch and Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu would swap faces *and* bodies, and while she would live the life of Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu, Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu could do anything she wanted with Switch’s body.

“I don’t like to be indebted to anyone. If you have anything left unfinished, a will, or even the desire to kill someone, I will do it for you!” Switch informed her generously.

Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu shook her head.

“No need to kill anyone.” Her face turned ice cold. “Switch, aren’t you afraid of getting in trouble with Obsidian if you harm me?”

Switch shrugged.

“Obsidian has been missing for two years, why would I be afraid?

“Don’t you find it strange?” Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu asked. “Because of Dong Tu, Obsidian nearly lost his life twice. It can’t be easy for him to cut all ties.” Her gaze was eerily fixed, as if she were seeing through Switch.

Switch wasn’t worried. She was officially one of the Monstrous Eighteen herself: if anyone wanted to fight, she would fight. Besides, it was Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu she’d messed with, not Obsidian’s woman.

“So you aren’t afraid of anyone in the world?” Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu asked.

“No, no one!” Switch laughed.

A voice interrupted them.

“You had better fear Liet Than!” The voice belonged to a figure who entered the hut carrying a bag.

“Who?” Switch asked incredulously. She heard the sound of wine bottles clinking together, and some kind of metal glinted in the light of the fire crackling in the fireplace. Switch canted her head and watched the new stranger carefully; she swung her hand and Switch caught it—and ended up holding a bottle of wine.

“Yes, more good wine!” Switch brought the bottle to her nose and breathed in deeply, reveling in the rich fragrance, and then she took a savoring sip.

Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu watched with wary eyes. She lifted her hand to catch a bottle of wine from the newcomer, reluctantly sniffed it, then put it down.

The stranger said, “Switch, this is your unlucky year. Be careful with Liet Than. Don’t say I didn’t warn you!”

The warning clearly angered Switch.

“Stargazer, if you want to say something, just spit it out. What the hell is Liet Than?”

The new stranger was Stargazer, the more mystical of the Monstrous Eighteen, an elderly woman whose words of prophecy were as accurate as those of the gods.

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CHAPTER 2

Unmatched Strength

Dong Tu searched all night. When she reached the hut, only Stargazer was left, sitting calmly on the floor eating oranges. Nearby, a streak of fresh blood marred the ground, and broken bottles of wine were scattered everywhere.

“Stargazer? Why are you here?” Dong Tu asked. They hadn’t seen each other in a while, and Stargazer’s presence was a welcome surprise.

“I’ve just been sitting here, waiting for you.” Stargazer smiled. “It’s been nearly two years. I wanted to see if you had gotten any taller and prettier. I was right, you have.”

Stargazer had, for some reason, been keenly interested in Dong Tu for quite a while. But in that moment, for Dong Tu, seeing Stargazer was like finding treasure.

“Did you see Switch with a very tall lady?” she immediately asked. “Switch kidnapped her.” She glanced around, noticing the scattered blood stains for the first time—and felt her stomach lurch in realization.

“The blood! Is it Lady Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu’s?”

Stargazer waved a hand, unconcerned.

“Not at all.”

“What happened here?”

The old woman shook her head.

“Switch is having a bad year. She had a little…clash, earlier. Nothing to worry about. She’ll recover.”

“How about Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu?”

“Safe.”

“So where is Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu now?” Dong Tu asked, continuing to fire off questions. Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu was no fighter, and neither was Stargazer, so it was unlikely that the blood belonged to the old woman, either. Still, there it was; perhaps someone had recently come to fight with Switch and saved Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu.

Stargazer took a deep breath.

“What you are looking for is in the cave under Tien Thuc waterfall. This is not a lucky year—beware of water-related accidents. And now, it’s time for me to go.”

“Wait!” Dong Tu stopped her. Knowing that Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu was safe was reassuring, but she wasn’t finished. She had been looking forward to reuniting with Stargazer for a long time, and still had so many questions, but a pair of them burned more insistently than the others.

“Do you know how Obsidian is doing? I’ve learned the Sunlight Strike. When can I see him again?”

Stargazer swallowed the last bite of her orange, dusted off her trousers, and stood up.

“Child, I came all this way to see you after two years and you’re only worried about Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu and that Obsidian. You still haven’t even asked how I am doing!” she scolded, but there was no real bite to her tone.

A continued rush of questions threatened to come spilling out of Dong Tu, but Stargazer’s talent and time were as precious as gold, and sunrise

was upon them. It had been a busy night, and it was time for breakfast.

Dong Tu held her hand and refused to let go. Stargazer had said that if Dong Tu learned the Sunlight Strike, she could see Obsidian again, and Dong Tu had dedicated everything to learning the technique: she had searched out and poured over every bit of information she could get her hands on, training day and night with all her hope hanging on the promise of that prediction. But she hadn't seen anything special about the technique for many years.

What was the point? she thought. *What was she getting at when she directed me to practice it?*

"You don't feel anything special because of your chi," Stargazer explained, as if reading Dong Tu's mind. "As I said earlier, what you're looking for is in the cave under Tien Thuc waterfall!"

Dong Tu just blinked at her. Stargazer stared silently for a moment, then huffed and added:

"You should look for Liet Than."

"Liet Than?" Dong Tu repeated, confused.

"Your fate with Obsidian depends on Liet Than," Stargazer insisted. She added nothing more, and hurried away with her beloved bag of jewels. Her hands were tied: every time she revealed the truth about the future, she felt her life get a little shorter. Her hair would turn a bit more gray, her skin would show a few more wrinkles, and her stomach would need more food. She had also found that the more she spoke, the easier it was to be wrong, so recently she had changed her tactics. Speaking more ambiguously and less overall made her predictions more likely to be correct.

Dong Tu watched her go in disappointment. For many years, there was only one thing she wanted to know—the whereabouts of Obsidian. Yet each time she asked, Stargazer gave her a different answer. She was beginning to acknowledge that Stargazer's predictions were fuzzy, with no definitive beginnings or ends.

And even if she had knowledge of the future, it would still be difficult for Dong Tu to change fate itself.

Two days later, following Stargazer's instructions, Dong Tu went to Tien Thuc Falls in search of Switch and Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu—where, lost in thought, Dong Tu slipped and fell straight down the waterfall, disappearing into the depths.

She had forgotten the prophet's warning.

She woke to the sound of a waterfall pounding in her ears.

Dong Tu came to consciousness slowly, and as her eyes blinked open, she took mental stock of her body and surroundings. Her head ached like it was being hammered, her whole body was sore, and between the dull roar of the water, the dark dampness of her surroundings, and the hard, uneven floor beneath her, she realized she had to be in a cave. Dong Tu felt around with her hands, trying desperately to remember how she'd ended up there, but she could barely remember her own name, let alone the events that had led to this. She stopped her search in shock: there was a straw mat underneath her! Her heart began to race as she realized someone had to have brought her there—and it stopped entirely when she realized she was wearing someone else's clothes.

As her vision cleared, Dong Tu spotted a fire flickering deeper inside the cave. She fumbled her way unsteadily toward the fire and into another chamber: the cave's ceiling expanded far above her, and it opened at the top to reveal a vivid sunset. A clear stream flowed over her bare feet, and soft green moss grew along its banks. But without her memories and not knowing if she was even safe, Dong Tu found herself too frightened to continue onward. As she turned to leave, she stumbled on a rock and fell to her knees.

Dong Tu jumped and looked up as a hand appeared out of the darkness; a young man stood there, bent forward to help her to her feet.

"Be careful not to get all wet again," he said, a smile evident in his voice.

Dong Tu couldn't make much out in the darkness as they walked, but his hand was warm and strong.

"Last name Ly, first name Minh Lam," the young man introduced himself. He led her over to the fire, where the flames lit up the cave and cast shifting shadows on the walls.

Ly Minh Lam was young, probably about Dong Tu's age. He had long bangs that fell to his cheekbones, and he would shake them out of his eyes with a graceful flip of his head. His face carried a certain elegance, with a high, slightly curved nose and a smirking mouth, and a mole sat just beneath one eye. It seemed to add an accent to every smile and glance, in ways that spoke of mischief and play. Ly Minh Lam was also fairly tall, with slim shoulders and long limbs, but he was leanly muscled in a way that made Dong Tu sure he was well-versed in the martial arts.

He was also wearing only underclothes; as Dong Tu looked closer, she realized she was wearing his outer layers. Whoever he was, he certainly

didn’t seem like a bad person. After considering him for a while, Dong Tu finally dared to speak up.

“Did you bring me here?”

Ly Minh Lam nodded, his lips parting in a smile.

“Don’t mention it. I help anyone who’s in trouble.”

Dong Tu performed a gesture of thanks for saving her life. The pair fell silent, and she took the opportunity to take a closer look around the stone cave.

“Are you…the only one living here?” she asked hesitantly.

Ly Minh Lam raised an eyebrow.

“Why do you ask?”

“Did you change my clothes?”

“Oh, this is about your wet clothes?” Minh Lam laughed. “The way you acted, I thought it was more serious. It’s not spring yet and the water is cold. If I hadn’t changed your clothes, you would have frozen to death!”

The full ramifications of being changed out of her wet clothes struck Dong Tu then, and she flushed bright red.

“D-did you see all of me?” she stammered.

“It’s not like there was much to see,” Minh Lam answered, shrugging.

Ly Minh Lam’s attitude didn’t make her feel any better. Men and women weren’t supposed to see each other like that! Not even Obsidian had seen her naked, but now a complete stranger had. How could he be so blasé?

“I’ve saved many beauties from the waterfall,” Minh Lam chuckled, his body shaking with mirth. “You’re not the first. I’m a lucky man.”

The more Dong Tu blushed, the more he laughed, and the more he laughed, the more her embarrassment melted into anger. Falling off a

waterfall, being knocked unconscious, and nearly dying from cold excused Minh Lam from having to hold with propriety when he'd saved her, but she wished he would behave more like a gentleman! Maybe he had saved her life, but she still wanted to punch him so badly. It was not a laughing matter!

"Well, did you do anything *else* to me?" Dong Tu asked cautiously.

"Do what?" Minh Lam shot back, feigning ignorance.

"Like—like…" Dong Tu couldn't form the words. She was already too embarrassed to get her question out.

"Like kissing you while you were unconscious?" Minh Lam said seriously. He wasn't laughing anymore, and stared through her with an uncomfortable kind of knowing. The words turned her to ice.

He was obviously referring to Obsidian, but despite the plethora of rumors, very few people actually knew Obsidian had kissed her like that—which meant he knew exactly who she was, and who Obsidian was. Between his build, his attitude, and his knowledge, Dong Tu realized: he had to be connected to the Monstrous Eighteen!

Minh Lam raised an eyebrow at Dong Tu's suddenly panicked expression.

"Well, well! Perhaps the rumors were true!" He reached out to grab her, and Dong Tu ducked away instinctively. Not knowing for sure if he wanted to test her fighting skills or if he was reaching for something else, Dong Tu lashed out with a kick; Minh Lam blocked it, and the two found themselves in a full-blown fight.

It was easy to see he was being gentle with her, but she still struggled to block him. After two failed moves, Dong Tu had to dredge together all of

her chi and every scrap of knowledge she had to counter Minh Lam. It didn't take her long to understand that he was way out of her league, but she couldn't let herself give up. Ly Minh Lam changed tactics abruptly, and rather than continue his attacks, he instead gathered his chi to form a whirlwind in his palm. The wind gradually grew into a tornado, forming a protective barrier around him, and all of Dong Tu's moves just bounced off the wind like it was a shield.

Minh Lam pressed forward, pinning her to the ground. The force of the winds whirling around him kept her there until she became too tired to struggle, and when Dong Tu finally gave in, he released his chi, brushed the dust off his shirt, and scoffed at her.

"You're not very good. Do you want to learn my Whirlwind technique?"

Dong Tu scrambled up from the ground, still angry, and glared at Ly Minh Lam. *This young man has some formidable strength*, she thought. *That move he did just now, Whirlwind or whatever, seemed like it was entirely internal.* Dong Tu could no longer tell whether he was good or evil, her friend or foe.

Seeing that the situation was becoming tense, Minh Lam held up his hands in surrender.

"I've heard rumors about you for a long time, and I just want to see how good you were. Please don't hold it against me. Or are you still angry about me changing your clothes? I was joking about that; Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu did it. Are you happy now? No hard feelings?"

Upon hearing that tidbit, the tension in her body finally, visibly relaxed.

"Wait, you know Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu?"

Minh Lam nodded.

“The other night, I passed by a hut and saw someone in danger, so I helped her out.” He wagged a finger at her in mock reproof. “Lady Tuyet Hoa has more manners than you, so she politely thanked me for saving her life instead of punching her savior like you did.”

Dong Tu blushed again, but before she could speak, another person interrupted them.

“My darling hero, please stop making fun of Lady Luu.” The voice came from a tall figure who entered the cave. The light of the fire illuminated her beautifully radiant face as she drew closer: Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu smiled and tossed a string of freshly caught fish toward Minh Lam.

“Aha, dinner is here!” Minh Lam was delighted. He took the string of fish and threaded them onto a stick, ignoring Dong Tu and Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu as they were reunited.

Dong Tu gasped quietly and embraced her friend; Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu appeared to be perfectly healthy, and Dong Tu felt like a burden she had been carrying for days finally fell off.

The smell of campfire and delicious grilled fish was fragrant in the air. Dong Tu was relieved to learn that after she had surfaced just beyond the base of the waterfall, Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu had indeed been the one to change her clothes.

“Oh, come on! What’s the difference, whether I or Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu did it?” Minh Lam complained.

“Of course it’s different!” Dong Tu fired back. “Have you never lived in a civilized society? Men and women obviously can’t freely undress each

other.”

Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu was a bit more masculine than Dong Tu, but she was still a woman. It was different between women.

Ly Minh Lam ignored her, grinning to himself as he grilled the fish. Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu rotated the grilled fish and glanced at her companions. Dong Tu followed her friend’s eyes down to the fish and noticed that Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu had many finger-shaped burns on her hand.

With a start, Dong Tu realized that the wounds were characteristic of Switch’s attacks. She scooted closer and took Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu’s hand to examine the wound. The taller woman pulled it back, but not before Dong Tu caught her pulse. It was worryingly weak.

“Your heart rate is very weak. Are you injured?” Dong Tu began to look her over more closely. Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu shook her head.

“You should let me give you a little strength,” Dong Tu continued anyway. “Your chi is so weak, you could get sick if you’re not careful.”

Her friend shook her head again.

“It’s normal for me. When I was born, I almost died, so I’ve always been a little sickly. You don’t need to worry.”

Dong Tu was still concerned. She knew that being saved by Ly Minh Lam after facing Switch was definitely not a small matter for her friend. Perhaps Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu was traumatized, but was doing her best to hide it.

But talking about Switch had reminded Dong Tu of something.

“Oh great hero, how did you save Lady Tuyet Hoa from the hands of the Skinwalker?” she asked curiously. “Were you really able to beat Switch?”

Switch, of course, would never have given up Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu without a serious fight. In order to bring Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu to the cave, someone would have *had* to defeat her.

“Oh, it was nothing,” he replied with a careless wave of his hand. “She was no serious opponent. I just put in a few slaps and that was that. I’ve always hated people who like to bully others. I gave her a good beating.”

Dong Tu was still doubtful. Switch was one of the Monstrous Eighteen, and almost no ordinary people could beat her. Minh Lam could see her skepticism in her face.

“Follow me,” he said, waving her over with a fish skewer as he stood up.

Following the sound of his footsteps, Dong Tu and Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu fumbled their way into another, darker chamber. It held only a small mat in the corner, and someone was lying there, motionless.

Dong Tu approached the mat. Recognizing the clothes that Switch was wearing the day before, she rushed over to help her up—but Switch didn’t move. Her head just lolled limply onto Dong Tu’s chest. Dong Tu tried to wake her, but Switch still didn’t respond. That was when Dong Tu realized: her face was gone. She had no eyes, nose, or mouth. Nothing. Just blankness.

“S-Switch?” Dong Tu stammered. “Switch, what happened to you?”

Switch’s whole body was as soft as noodles, and no matter how hard Dong Tu shook her, she wouldn’t respond.

“Ly Minh Lam, what have you done to Switch?!”

“Don’t worry, she’s okay.” Minh Lam leisurely chewed a bite of fish. “That’s what she really looks like. Without another replacement face, she

can’t talk. Her pressure points are all locked up, and her chi has locked itself in, so she won’t die—but from now on, she can’t harm a soul.”

Dong Tu put her head to Switch’s chest and listened to her heartbeat. It was still beating normally, and her pulse felt steady as well. Minh Lam was telling the truth.

She was shocked. There was no way Ly Minh Lam was just a commoner. He had to be a master, to beat Switch like that: Switch had always been arrogant, walking around like she was the queen of the universe, but she was also strong and skilled enough to back her arrogance up.

“Who are you?” she asked Minh Lam, pulling herself out of her thoughts. “Are you one of the Monstrous Eighteen?”

“What qualifies someone as one of the Eighteen?” Minh Lam raised his eyebrows. “I don’t concern myself with the rumors of the world.”

“Are you Liet Than?” Dong Tu tried again, finally remembering her conversation with Stargazer.

Ly Minh Lam stopped chewing and frowned at her. Blowing at the bangs which covered his eyes, he narrowed his eyes further and studied her rather than answer. The pale mole under his eye seemed to laugh at her.

“Wait a second, you know about Liet Than too?” Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu hesitantly interjected.

It turned out that, for her own unknown reasons, Stargazer had told many people about the mysterious Liet Than. Dong Tu, Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu, and Switch had all received a prophecy involving those two words.

Minh Lam waved for everyone to return to the first cave, leaving Switch to lie by herself. Dong Tu followed, but kept looking back over her shoulder at Switch’s powerless body. She was worried about the other woman, but

she knew that if Minh Lam had wanted to kill her, he would have done it already. *Switch has always been a wanderer, causing trouble and harm everywhere*, Dong Tu reminded herself. *If she just stays here, incapacitated, who knows? It may be better for everyone in the long run.*

Returning to the campfire, Minh Lam finally finished eating his fish. He stretched, patting his stomach, but even though he seemed to be stuffed, his belly didn't look any bigger. After many years of practicing martial arts, his abs were rock hard—a meal of fish didn't affect them at all. Refreshed from the stretch, he jumped onto a rock.

"Which one of you two beauties would like to sleep with me tonight?" he called out playfully. "Or do you two girls just want to sleep together?"

Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu picked up a pile of gravel and threw it straight at him. Minh Lam didn't even bother to dodge—the pebbles never reached him. They broke into fine powder before his face as if they had hit an invisible wall.

"No worries! I'll just sleep alone…again…" Minh Lam moaned in mock self-pity. He laid down, facing the stone wall, and fell asleep almost instantly.

His snores echoed off the cave walls.

Dong Tu lay down, but she couldn't sleep. Thoughts whirled through her head. Who was Ly Minh Lam? Did his strength have anything to do with the Sunlight Strike? What or who was Liet Than? *Was* Ly Minh Lam actually Liet Than? After two uneventful years, why was Liet Than being mentioned so often? Could it be that Stargazer wanted to tell Dong Tu to

learn from Minh Lam so that she could improve and use the Sunlight Strike to its fullest extent?

Dong Tu huffed in frustration and sat up, only to see Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu still awake by the fire. She went and sat next to her.

Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu stared into the flames, absentmindedly rubbing the wound on her hand. Her gaze was even more wistful and distant.

The burns Switch left on Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu's wrist must be sore, Dong Tu thought. Without asking questions, she took her friend's hands and used her chi to help heal the wounds, slowly transferring her inner power to Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu.

Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu was startled at first, then gently squeezed Dong Tu's hands. It was cold in the cave, and so were her long, slender hands. When Dong Tu transferred chi, her fingers began to warm up. Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu fondly stroked Dong Tu's hands and watched with intent curiosity as the waves of energy slowly entered her body.

Dong Tu guessed Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu had never been given energy like that before, especially when she began to tremble. At first the strange sensation scared her, but it didn't take long for her to relax into it.

"Take a long breath, like this," Dong Tu instructed reassuringly, "then slowly exhale. Try to relax your body, Lady Tuyet Hoa."

Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu obediently followed Dong Tu's lead, and she looked up into Dong Tu's face with gratefulness heavy in her gaze.

"Do you feel more comfortable now?" Dong Tu went on. With a bit of Dong Tu's inner energy, she should feel a little warmer.

Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu nodded.

"Yes, it feels much better. Thank you, Miss Luu."

Dong Tu nodded, and continued to give Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu energy.

Inner energy, which many normal people had, was different from physical strength. Physical strength was used when one lifted heavy objects or exerted power. It made the body move, and was a result of physical muscles. Inner energy, or chi, was the flow of invisible energy inside the body. Unlike physical energy, not everyone knew how to tap into it. Martial arts masters mainly worked to control and enhance their chi, setting them apart from ordinary people.

Dong Tu was no martial arts master, but had learned enough to gain at least some control over her own chi. She could utilize her chi to treat minor injuries, or enhance her strength during a fight.

There were many levels of martial arts masters above Dong Tu, with their respective talents depending on control of their chi. For example, most masters could use their chi to fly like a bird. They could also use chi to master fighting techniques that would allow them to battle dozens of people at once.

The highest level of all was that of great masters like Switch, or any of the Monstrous Eighteen. Those masters could use their chi to move mountains and perform many other extraordinary acts. It was why Dong Tu was certain Minh Lam had to be a great master himself, something she continued to ponder over as she rubbed Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu’s hands.

She could tell just from that simple act that her friend belonged to the class of people without chi. When their hands touched, Dong Tu immediately knew that Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu had never transferred inner energy or practiced martial arts. Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu was very young and

healthy, but on the inside, her small chi was weak and fragmented and effectively nonexistent.

With chi as frail as hers, Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu should be walking around like a very old person, Dong Tu realized. She should have been sick, near death's door. Yet regardless of her weak chi and the things she'd endured, Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu retained a remarkably calm appearance. Dong Tu secretly admired her strength.

Her friend's body grew warmer, and her face began to look more and more fresh. Clasping Dong Tu's hands in appreciation, Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu leaned back into her chest and slowly fell asleep. Dong Tu smiled. She wrapped her arms around Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu as if embracing a little sister, and then drifted off to sleep as well.

Unlikely circumstances had led to friendship, and the challenges they faced had given birth to love; and Dong Tu and Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu remained in each other's embrace for the rest of the night.

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CHAPTER 3

Lingering Memories

When Dong Tu woke up the next morning, Ly Minh Lam had already left with Switch.

Dong Tu and Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu helped each other out of the cave. They struggled to climb back up the falls, searching for the road that would take them back to the rest of their escort. The path was steep and rocky, precarious even during the day; and at night, they would lean against each other for warmth beside the crackling fire.

To Dong Tu, Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu didn't *look* like a lady in need of protection, neither in appearance nor personality. Her height and bearing put off a constant air of strength and dignity. After days of climbing, her makeup had worn almost entirely away, and out of the corner of her eye Dong Tu began to mistake her features and temperament for those of a man. Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu had clear eyes, and an enchanting stillness and peace that was magnetic. One could see clouds drifting in the sky when looking into her eyes, like transparent ice at the end of winter, reflecting heaven and earth, plants and trees. They were pure and fresh.

Dong Tu looked at her own reflection in the water. It was early spring, and plants were beginning to wake and stir. Winter's chill still lingered, but green shoots and buds were already pushing their way out into the air. She splashed water over her face, the startling cold zinging through her body

and waking her up properly. Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu did the same, and Dong Tu watched as the spring water streamed in rivulets down her nose, forming a straight line down the center of her face and becoming a gleaming highlight on her lips. There was no powder left on her face, and without her dangling earrings and long hair, there would be no way to differentiate between Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu and a beautiful man.

Dong Tu thought it was just a show. Inside, Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu's spirit was fragile, just like her name—a snowflake dancing in the wind, pretty as a painting. But with one touch, the snowflake would melt into water.

Dong Tu no longer saw Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu as a client in need of protection, but also as her newest younger sibling. Dong Tu tried to help her as much as she could, picking wild berries and giving Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu anything else she found that was edible. Dong Tu even took the lead, on the lookout for any paths that she deemed too dangerous. If there were any suspicious sounds, she drew her sword without hesitation, and Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu was indescribably grateful.

Several days later, Bao Thuong and the two guards were finally found. It was Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu's wedding day, and the group was still more than two days away from Lac Do.

Worry drew lines of stress along Dong Tu's face and sat heavy in her eyes. She didn't know what would happen if they were a few days late, whether the other woman's in-laws would make things difficult for the Tuyet family or not. And she knew if she was worried, Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu had to be as well, and checked in with her regularly to make sure she was okay.

Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu was very good at hiding emotion. Happiness, sadness, worry, fatigue, jokes or seriousness, all were barely visible. Her default expression was calm, confident and a bit thoughtful. Even Dong Tu, who had been by her side day and night, could barely read her expressions, which mostly consisted of only two emotions. First was contemplation: Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu sometimes seemed to be pondering over something, like there was something she wanted to say but couldn't. It wasn't anything strange, and Dong Tu suspected she was worried about her upcoming marriage, and felt too awkward to express it.

Second was curiosity. Dong Tu often caught Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu's eyes watching her movements with some combination of curiosity and admiration, even when she wasn't doing anything remotely extraordinary.

"What does that look mean?" Dong Tu asked her one day.

"I was born like that," Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu replied, trying to brush it off. Pretty people often had a naturally curious-looking face, they couldn't blame her for it.

"But you don't look at Bao Thuong like that, do you," Dong Tu pressed. That got Bao Thuong's attention, and with no other way to worm herself out of answering, Lady Tuyet Hoa gave in.

"You're so small, but you always act like everyone's big sister. It amuses me." Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu raised her hands to measure their heights. Even when standing, the top of Dong Tu's head didn't even reach the taller woman's chin, but she always treated Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu like a weak little kid. Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu found it funny.

"Tuyet Hoa Phi Vu, I advise you not to underestimate me just because I'm short," Dong Tu snapped. "Your safety depends on me. In fact, you